

1 Schubert et al., 2001 basic equations

This document/section has a different approach to structure the derivation of the ALA: this is a summary of the derivation of the ALA done by Schubert et al., 2001. **red text means assumptions/approximations were made toward the ALA.**

1.1 Mass equation/continuity equation/conservation of mass

$$\frac{\partial \rho}{\partial t} + \frac{\partial}{\partial x_1}(\rho u_1) = \frac{1}{\rho} \frac{D\rho}{Dt} + \frac{\partial u_1}{\partial x_1} = 0 \quad (1)$$

where $\frac{D}{Dt}$ represents the material derivative (??). For incompressible flow, $\frac{D\rho}{Dt} = 0$, so eq 1 reduces to:

$$\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_i} = \nabla \cdot \mathbf{u} = 0 \quad (2)$$

For the special case of an incompressible fluid, $\frac{D\rho}{Dt} = 0$, so equation 2 reduces to

$$\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_i} = 0 \quad (3)$$

1.2 Momentum equations/conservation of momentum

Starting governing equation (6.4.1):

$$\rho \frac{Du_i}{Dt} = -\frac{\partial p}{\partial x_i} + \frac{\partial \tau_{ij}}{\partial x_j} + \rho g_i \quad (4)$$

we assume gravity g to be the only body force. The coriolis force is negligibly small in the Earth's mantle, and the centrifugal force due to the Earth's rotation is included in the gravity term.

In 2D, the momentum equation components are:

$$\rho \left(\frac{\partial u_x}{\partial t} + u_x \frac{\partial u_x}{\partial x} + u_y \frac{\partial u_x}{\partial y} \right) = -\frac{\partial p}{\partial x} + \frac{\partial \tau_{xx}}{\partial x} + \frac{\partial \tau_{xy}}{\partial y}, \quad (5)$$

$$\rho \left(\frac{\partial u_y}{\partial t} + u_x \frac{\partial u_y}{\partial x} + u_y \frac{\partial u_y}{\partial y} \right) = -\frac{\partial p}{\partial y} + \frac{\partial \tau_{xy}}{\partial x} + \frac{\partial \tau_{yy}}{\partial y} + \rho g. \quad (6)$$

Note that the assumption is made that gravity acts in the positive y-direction. Section 6.14?ext

1.3 Navier-Stokes equation

The local strain rate tensor e_{ij} is given by:

$$e_{ij} = \frac{1}{2} \left(\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_j} + \frac{\partial u_j}{\partial x_i} \right) \quad (7)$$

For a Newtonian, isotropic fluid, the relation between the deviatoric(!) stress tensor and the strain rate tensor is

$$\tau_{ij} = 2\mu e_{ij} + \lambda e_{kk} \delta_{ij} \quad (8)$$

Defining the bulk viscosity k_B :

$$\frac{\tau_{ii}}{3} = e_{ii} \left(\lambda + \frac{2}{3}\mu \right) = k_B e_{ii} \quad (9)$$

The combination of equations 8, 9 and 7 gives

$$\tau_{ij} = \mu \left(\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_j} + \frac{\partial u_j}{\partial x_i} \right) + \left(k_B - \frac{2}{3}\mu \right) \frac{\partial u_k}{\partial x_k} \delta_{ij} \quad (10)$$

and substitution of eq. 10 into eq. 4 gives

$$\rho \frac{Du_i}{Dt} = -\frac{\partial p}{\partial x_i} + \frac{\partial}{\partial x_j} \left[\mu \left(\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_j} + \frac{\partial u_j}{\partial x_i} \right) + \left(k_B - \frac{2}{3}\mu \right) \frac{\partial u_k}{\partial x_k} \delta_{ij} \right] + \rho g_i \quad (11)$$

For many fluids, k_B is taken to be zero (**Stokes assumption**), so eq. 10 becomes

$$\tau_{ij} = \mu \left(\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_j} + \frac{\partial u_j}{\partial x_i} - \frac{2}{3} \frac{\partial u_k}{\partial x_k} \delta_{ij} \right) \quad (12)$$

and eq. 11 becomes the Navier-Stokes equation:

$$\rho \frac{Du_i}{Dt} = -\frac{\partial p}{\partial x_i} + \frac{\partial}{\partial x_j} \left[\mu \left(\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_j} + \frac{\partial u_j}{\partial x_i} - \frac{2}{3} \frac{\partial u_k}{\partial x_k} \delta_{ij} \right) \right] + \rho g_i \quad (13)$$

for incompressible flow, equation 2 tells us $\frac{\partial u_k}{\partial x_k} = 0$, and together with a constant dynamic viscosity μ so eq. 13 reduces to:

$$\rho \frac{Du_i}{Dt} = -\frac{\partial p}{\partial x_i} + \mu \frac{\partial^2 u_i}{\partial x_j^2} + \rho g_i \quad (14)$$

This equation represents a balance between inertial forces $\left(\frac{Du_i}{Dt} \right)$, pressure forces $\left(\frac{\partial p}{\partial x_i} \right)$, viscous forces $\left(\mu \frac{\partial^2 u_i}{\partial x_j^2} \right)$ and the body force due to gravity (ρg_i)

1.4 Thermal energy equations/conservation of energy

Schubert et al., 2001 presents various different formulations of the energy equation.

The general form of the energy equation (6.9.1) is:

$$\rho T \frac{Ds}{Dt} = \tau_{ij} \frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_j} + \frac{\partial}{\partial x_j} \left(k \frac{\partial T}{\partial x_j} \right) + \rho H \quad (15)$$

The terms on the right side of 15 are, respectively, volumetric heat production rates due to viscous dissipation (internal friction), thermal conduction, and internal heat generation (radiogenic?). **Where it is assumed that Fourier's law of heat conduction for an isotropic medium is applicable:**

$$q_i = -k \frac{\partial T}{\partial x_i} \quad (16)$$

Where q_i is the heat flux vector. Additionally, the viscous dissipation term can be written as the dissipation function:

$$\Phi = \tau_{ij} \frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_j} \quad (17)$$

Inserting the definition of our deviatoric stress tensor with $k_B = 0$ (eq. ??), this becomes

$$\Phi = 2\mu \left\{ \frac{1}{2} \left(\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_j} + \frac{\partial u_j}{\partial x_i} \right) - \frac{1}{3} \left(\frac{\partial u_k}{\partial x_k} \right) \delta_{ij} \right\}^2 \quad (18)$$

For an incompressible and Newtonian fluid ($\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_i} = 0$), the dissipation function reduces to

$$\Phi = \frac{\mu}{2} \left(\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_j} + \frac{\partial u_j}{\partial x_i} \right)^2 \quad (19)$$

With various thermodynamic relationships:

$$\alpha = \frac{1}{v} \left(\frac{\partial v}{\partial T} \right)_p \quad (20)$$

$$c_p = T \left(\frac{\partial s}{\partial T} \right)_p \quad (21)$$

$$\left(\frac{\partial s}{\partial p} \right)_T = - \left(\frac{\partial v}{\partial T} \right)_p \quad (22)$$

It can be shown that

$$\frac{Ds}{Dt} = \frac{c_p}{T} \frac{DT}{Dt} - \frac{\alpha}{\rho} \frac{Dp}{Dt} \quad (23)$$

Plugging 23 into 15 gives

$$\begin{aligned} \rho c_p \frac{DT}{Dt} - \alpha T \frac{DP}{Dt} &= \frac{\partial}{\partial x_i} \left(k \frac{\partial T}{\partial x_i} \right) + \Phi + \rho H \\ \rho c_p \left(\frac{DT}{Dt} - \frac{\alpha T}{\rho c_p} \frac{DP}{Dt} \right) &= \frac{\partial}{\partial x_i} \left(k \frac{\partial T}{\partial x_i} \right) + \Phi + \rho H \end{aligned} \quad (24)$$

2 Approximate equations

In this section, Schubert derives the approximate forms of the equations of conservation of energy and momentum appropriate to mantle convection.

2.1 Equation of state (density ρ)

From now on, density ρ is considered a function of temperature T and pressure p only, neglecting the density changes associated with mineral phase transitions and changes in chemical composition.

Most of the density change in the mantle is due to hydrostatic compression. The mantle density increases by approximately 65% between the surface and the core-mantle boundary. This is Schubert's justification for assuming a linearized equation of state for mantle density:

$$\begin{aligned} \rho &= \bar{\rho}(\bar{T}, \bar{p}) + \rho' \\ \rho &= \bar{\rho}(\bar{T}, \bar{p}) + \left(\frac{\partial \rho}{\partial p} \right)_T p' + \left(\frac{\partial \rho}{\partial T} \right)_p T' \\ \rho &= \bar{\rho}(\bar{T}, \bar{p}) + \bar{\rho} \chi_T p' - \bar{\alpha} \bar{\rho} T' \end{aligned} \quad (25)$$

with

$$\begin{aligned} T &= \bar{T} + T' \\ p &= \bar{p} + p' \end{aligned} \quad (26)$$

Where the overbar ($\bar{\rho}$) refers to a reference state and the primes (ρ') departures from it. The reference state is assumed motionless and steady:

- motionless: $\bar{u}_i = 0$
- steady: $\frac{\partial \bar{u}_i}{\partial t} = 0$
- motionless and steady: $\frac{D\bar{u}_i}{Dt} = 0$
- $\tau_{ij} = \mu \left(\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial x_j} + \frac{\partial u_j}{\partial x_i} - \frac{2}{3} \frac{\partial u_k}{\partial x_k} \delta_{ij} \right) = 0$ (12)

This reduces the momentum equation (13, 4) to its static form:

$$0 = - \frac{\partial \bar{p}}{\partial x_i} + \bar{\rho} g_i \quad (27)$$

Integrating equation 27 results in the hydrostatic equation. Further needed for the calculation of the reference state is the equation for the adiabatic temperature gradient (since the reference state temperature is assumed adiabatic)

$$\left(\frac{\partial T}{\partial x_i}\right)_s = \frac{\alpha T g_i}{c_p} \quad (28)$$

And a specification of the reference state equation of state $\bar{\rho} = \bar{\rho}(\bar{T}, \bar{p})$.

2.2 Nondimensionalization

Now, the linearized equation of state (25) will be nondimensionalized with scaling factors consisting of representative/characteristic values presented in table 2. With these, dimensionless variables (denoted with an asterisk *) are introduced by dividing the dimensional variables with their characteristic counterpart. Rewriting the linearized equation of state (25) in terms of these nondimensional variables gives:

$$\frac{\rho^*}{\bar{\rho}} = 1 + \bar{\chi}_T^* p' M^2 Pr - \bar{\alpha}^* T' \epsilon \quad (29)$$

where

$$M^2 = \frac{k_r^2 \chi_{T_r}}{\rho_r c_p^2 b^2}, \quad Pr = \frac{\mu_r c_{p_r}}{k_r}, \quad \epsilon = \alpha_r \Delta T_r \quad (30)$$

which are the Mach number (squared, measuring the influence of compressibility), Prandtl number (ratio of momentum diffusivity to thermal diffusivity, or, equivalently the ratio between advection and conduction) and the fractional density change due to temperature variations, respectively. I refer to table 3 for an overview of all dimensionless parameters discussed in this document. Plugging in the values from table 2 gives $Pr \approx 2.5 \times 10^{23}$, which is considered practically infinite, and $M^2 \approx 10^{-33}$ and consequently $M^2 Pr \approx 2 \times 10^{-10} \ll 1$

3 Appendix 1: tables of constants and reference/scaling values used

Table 1: Constants used by Schubert et al., 2001

Constant	Value	Name
k_b	0	Bulk viscosity
α		thermal expansivity
χ_T		isothermal compressibility
c_v		specific heat at constant volume
c_p		specific heat at constant pressure
χ_a		adiabatic compressibility
k		thermal conductivity
H		rate of internal heat production per unit mass
K_a		adiabatic bulk modulus
K_T		isothermal bulk modulus

Table 2: Reference values used by Schubert et al., 2001

Symbol	Value	Description
ΔT_r		Characteristic temperature difference driving thermal convection
χ_{T_r}		Representative isothermal compressibility
α_r		Representative thermal expansivity
u_r	$\frac{k_r}{\rho_r c_{p_r} b}$	Velocity scale (follows from assuming $Pe = 1$)
μ_r	10^{21} Pa s	Representative viscosity
b		Depth of convecting region
p_r	$\frac{\mu_r u_r}{b}$	Scale for dynamic pressure variations
k_r	$4 \text{ W m}^{-1} \text{ K}^{-1}$	Reference value thermal conductivity
c_{p_r}	$1 \text{ kJ kg}^{-1} \text{ K}^{-1}$	Reference specific heat at constant pressure
t_r	$\frac{b}{u_r} = \frac{\rho_r c_{p_r} b^2}{k}$	reference timescale

Table 3: Dimensionless parameters and their values for the Earth's mantle

Parameter	Definition	Value	Description
Pr	$\frac{\mu_r c_{p_r}}{k_r}$	2.5×10^{23}	Prandtl number
M^2	$\frac{k_r^2 \chi_{T_r}}{\rho_r c_{p_r}^2 b^2}$	10^{-33}	Mach number (squared)
ϵ	$\alpha_r \Delta T_r$		Fractional density change due to temperature variations